

Time Management Guide

We recently spoke with a Knobull user who was feeling overwhelmed by her workload and unable to break free from the monotonous routine of working from 6 a.m. to 6 p.m. every day.

She reached out to our chat with her Knobull expert seeking advice on improving her time management skills. This question surprised us because we never considered time management top student priority. We tend to avoid rigid productivity systems, believing that they stifle creativity.

We were curious about why this student thought we might have something to offer her. She mentioned the variety of projects I undertake, including communications strategy, leadership coaching, Knobull work, and research.

It wasn’t until after our chat session ended that it dawned on the expert.. We don’t focus on time management; instead, we focus on energy management. Somewhere along the way, we realized that the duration of a task is secondary to the energy we invest in it. It’s possible to work six hours on a task that energizes us and leaves us feeling refreshed and ready for the next challenge.

Alternatively, we could spend three hours on a draining and unfulfilling task, leaving us feeling exhausted and needing to take a break for the rest of the day.

From a productivity perspective, it's beneficial to create lists and check off tasks as we complete them. However, the satisfaction we derive from crossing items off the list comes from the intentionality behind what we include on the list. If everything on the list is an energy drain, how will it feel to accomplish those tasks?

A Knobull team member recently shared an insightful concept that expanded our understanding of this idea.

He spoke about the addictive nature of frustration, which can be triggered by any default negative emotion. He explained that frustration causes us to feel adrenaline-pumped and stressed.

Frustration can be a negative emotion, but it’s understandable to feel it when you’re not aware of what’s happening. Recognizing frustration as an addictive response can be enlightening. More importantly, frustration traps energy, preventing it from being channeled into more productive and creative pursuits.

Reflecting on this, as well as the experiences of many users who feel trapped in an endless cycle, it’s clear that addictive hormones like adrenaline are exacerbated, if not promoted, by hustle culture.

Time management is often touted as a solution to burnout and a way to survive in this culture. However, over-emphasizing time management can actually sustain and perpetuate hustle culture.

Instead of focusing solely on squeezing every moment from our days, we should shift our focus to the energy we create, use, and maintain within our lives. This requires awareness, discernment, and making conscious choices.

Awareness

Energy comes in different forms. Some types are frenetic and driven, while others are open, free, and vital. The latter type of energy is sustainable and can be derived from any activity that aligns with our strengths and passions, leaving us feeling empowered and expansive. Coaching can help individuals like those who use our Job Search program at discover and harness their natural energy.

Discernment

It’s important to identify which activities create which type of energy and choose those that expand our horizons. Similarly, we should recognize which activities drain our energy. For example, organizing a closet or creating a budget may be overwhelming for some, while others find them deeply satisfying and rejuvenating. While it may not be possible to eliminate all energy-draining activities, time management alone won’t solve the problem. Knobull’s edX courses can also provide valuable guidance in managing our energy effectively.

Choices and sacrifices

Making conscious choices and being willing to make sacrifices are essential for cultivating a balanced and fulfilling life. By prioritizing activities that align with our values and passions, we can create a more sustainable and energizing routine.

Choices are unavoidable. We can’t do everything. However, if we’re mindful and discerning about what we accept and reject based on their impact on our energy levels, we can at least increase our energy and satisfaction.

What if we've already tipped the scales towards negative, energy-draining emotions? In that case, we need to recognize the emotional hijack and breathe into it. We should observe, acknowledge, and continue to breathe into it.

When we're frustrated, the goal is to notice it, name it, choose a change. If we don't do this, we're on the path to an energy drain. This presence is like rocket fuel that fills our limbs with energy and light, allowing us to step out of the story of what's happening and into the energy itself. This energy harness brings the creativity to make the right decision.

Time Management: The Key to Success

1. **Understand the Limitations of Time:** No matter how organized we are, there are only 24 hours in a day.

2. **Identify Time Wasters:** Many of us are victims of time-wasters that steal valuable time. Take some time to identify your time bandits.

3. **Set Time Management Goals:** Remember, the goal of time management is to change your behaviors, not just manage your time.

4. **Develop a Time Management Plan:** This plan should be an extension of your time management goals.

5. **Utilize Time Management Tools:** Whether it's a Day-Timer, a software program, or a phone app, these tools can help you physically manage your time.

6. **Learn to Delegate and/or Outsource:** Delegation can be challenging, but it's an important skill to develop.

7. **Establish Routines and Stick to Them:** While crises may arise, sticking to routines will increase your productivity.

8. **Set Time Limits for Tasks:** For example, reading and answering emails can consume your entire day if you let them. To get help, chat with us.

For added assistance, chat with your Knobull learning and career search expert.